

PRESSURES FOR CHANGE

In Asian societies today, the traditional rural ways of life and religious beliefs conflict with an increasingly money-oriented way of life, influenced by the West. As Asian societies become more open to western influences, so the pressures on traditional ways of life will intensify. Societies react to pressures for change in different ways. In Afghanistan, for example, religious leaders violently opposed western ideas, leading to the setting up of a hardline republic based on a strict interpretation of Islamic law.



In Afghanistan, the hardline Islamic Taliban government banned videos and ordered them all to be destroyed.

The influence of the US and capitalism can be seen on the streets of Tokyo, in Japan.



WESTERN INFLUENCE

In some societies, change happens gradually and without violent demonstrations. In Japan, for example, economic development was seen by its rulers as a way of avoiding becoming dependent on European nations. Japan has therefore accepted Western capitalism while still managing to preserve many traditional Japanese values. Even China, so long closed to Western ideas, is now enthusiastically embracing capitalism.

Kazakh people in northern China outside a tent known as a yurt



NOMADIC EXISTENCE

The collapse of the USSR has led to a revival of traditional ways of life among the nomads of central Asia. Goods that were made in factories, such as felt, which is used to line the inside of nomads' tents, ceased to be available and now have to be made by hand using traditional methods. The same is true when it comes to moving. In recent years, many nomads have moved their belongings around in vehicles, but gasoline is now in very short supply, so nomads have returned to using camels and horses.



OIL AND THE MIDDLE EAST

Before oil was discovered, many desert countries in the Middle East were very poor. Oil has transformed their fortunes. More than two-thirds of the world's known reserves of crude oil and a third of all the natural gas occur here. Countries have become wealthy through the export of oil and natural gas throughout the world. New cities have sprung up, such as Dubai (shown above), and foreign workers have arrived in great numbers.

Shaded areas on the map show Southeast Asia's newly industrializing countries.



LITTLE TIGERS

Following in the footsteps of Japan, a number of Southeast Asian countries looked to make the most of their cheap and plentiful supply of workers to rapidly boost their economies. These "Little Tigers" achieved great success in the final decades of the 20th century. However, they are now having to deal with the side effects of rapid industrialization – pollution, unemployment, poverty in rural areas, and new cheaper competition that has begun to emerge elsewhere.

ROLE OF WOMEN

Women's lives differ hugely over such a large continent, influenced by each nation's culture, religion, and politics. In some areas, such as in India and the Islamic countries of the Middle East, the vast majority of the workforce is male. Yet Islamic women in Southeast Asian countries such as Indonesia often work outside the home. In other areas, such as communist China and North Korea, and the former communist republics of the USSR, women make up a large proportion of the workforce and carry out most household chores.

Women in the workforce

This chart shows the percentage of men and women in the workforce in five countries.

